DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

How Does Shema Bring Blessing?

Derech Hashem 4:4:3-5

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 4, paragraphs 3-5 (the start of paragraph 5) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 10 February 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The two principles of Shema

So far: first, Yihud Hashem, the unity of God. There is no power or influence apart from Him, and we say so in *Hashem Ehad*. The purpose of creation is for us to remove the bad and choose good, and when we do, we reveal God's oneness. Second, *Kabbalat Ol Malkhut Shamayim*, accepting the yoke of His kingdom, in *Barukh Shem Kevod Malkhuto*. Elohim is God; Adon Kol implies association; Melekh means a relationship. Because He is the King, we are His people, and that builds the relationship.

Paragraph 3: recognising the King brings good

These two principles have great consequences for the rectification of all creation. The world is set up so that when creatures acknowledge God's oneness and kingdom, there is good and tranquillity, blessing and peace increase. When the servants rebel and do not acknowledge Him, good is lacking, darkness grows and evil dominates.

"It's very logical." If you recognise me as king, I want to give to you. If you do not, why should I provide for you?

A participant asked whether this refers to the Jewish people or all mankind. The Rabbi noted that the Ramhal speaks throughout of "creatures", never specifically of Jews. Jews have an obligation to proclaim Yihud Hashem; non-Jews do not say Shema, but under the seven Noahide laws they must not deny it. He mentioned the Lubavitch campaign to spread awareness of the Noahide laws, and said we have some duty here too.

If God is revealed and rules, there will be great good, light and holiness, and evil will be subdued. "This is why I say this every year: don't waste your prayers praying for physical, material things. Just pray for Hashem to be Melekh." Once He is recognised as King, everything else falls into place. If He is not recognised, He conceals Himself, and evil dominates. "And this is the reason for evil in this world."

Bowing at Barukh Shem

The Ben Ish Hai writes, from the Zohar, that when saying *Barukh Shem Kevod Malkhuto*, one should lower the head at the word *Malkhuto* and then raise it again, to draw down the influence into the world. Now it makes sense: first we declare God's unity, then we accept His kingship, and then the blessing can come down.

Every day Israel strengthens itself in these two principles, accepting the kingdom and acknowledging it with mouth and heart. "You can't just say it without understanding what you're saying." Through this the evil is subdued, blessing comes down, and the world becomes more and more rectified, until its final completion.

Paragraph 4: the world will be perfected anyway

Even if we do not do this, the world is still heading in that direction. There are two levels. Mashiah will come by a set time, but we have the ability to bring him earlier. Regardless of what we do, there is a general tikkun to which the world is being led.

A participant asked whether this process is happening now regardless of us. The Rabbi: the system God set up ensures that the world will end up perfect somehow, even if we do nothing. But God wanted it to happen through us. Why? The group recalled Part 1: so that we choose the good. When you choose it, it becomes part of you rather than simply being given to you. God wants us to bring perfection so that we ourselves become perfect, and so that we can cleave to Him, since only He is perfect.

And when we testify to His oneness and attribute everything to Him, He reveals Himself to us. We reveal not only the purpose of the world but perfection itself.

Paragraph 5: ready to give one's life

Now a new idea, tied to Yihud Hashem. The Ben Ish Hai and other sefarim write that one should be willing to give up one's life when saying Shema. Jews went to their deaths with the words of Shema; almost none of us will face that test, yet morning and evening we have a misvah to be genuinely willing.

The Ramhal says that an essential part of this misvah is to resolve in one's mind to give up one's life, and to accept every kind of suffering and death for the sanctification of God's name, and it is considered as if one had done so. Great consequences follow from this.

The Rabbi stressed a point that is less recognised: the Ramhal includes suffering, not only death. If someone threatens to beat you unless you bow down, that too is mesirut nefesh, and sometimes it can be easier to give up one's life than to endure torture. A participant asked whether serious illness borne while still recognising God's oneness is also part of it. "Of course, 100%."

Why does this belong to Shema? Willingness to give one's life says: I have no existence of my own; everything I have is from You, so if something goes against Your will, there is no point in my existing. A participant mentioned Yishak at the Akedah. "If you live your life with this principle, that there's nothing else in this universe but HaKadosh Barukh Hu, then it's easy. The problem is, it's not easy, because we don't live our lives like that." It is the real test of belief in

Yihud Hashem, and no one knows how he will act until truly tested. That is why at *Hashem Ehad* one thinks of the four deaths of beit din.

He repeated the advice of Rabbi Elimelekh of Lizhensk, some two hundred years ago: if you lie in bed unable to sleep, picture a great fire and those around you demanding that you convert, and see yourself ready to jump into it. That is the misvah of giving one's life, available at any time.

Summary

- Acknowledging God's unity and kingship draws blessing into the world; denial brings concealment and evil.
- Pray above all for God to be recognised as King, and the rest will follow.
- The world will reach perfection regardless, but God wants us to bring it so that we become perfect.
- Shema includes a resolve to give one's life, and to bear suffering, for Kiddush Hashem.
- Readiness to give one's life is the true test of believing that nothing exists apart from God.

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